

AFRICA

THE SECOND LARGEST CONTINENT, Africa is a land of contrasts. To the north lies the great Sahara, the largest desert in the world, yet the central equatorial area is covered by dense tropical rain forests, while farther south a series of grassy plateaus (areas of flat highland) give way to narrow coastal plains. Major mountain ranges include the Atlas in the north and the Ruwenzori range on the Uganda-Democratic Republic of Congo border. Africa's highest mountain is Kilimanjaro, a dormant volcano, in Tanzania. To the east is the Great Rift Valley, which contains several huge lakes. Some of the world's longest rivers drain the continent, including the Nile, Niger, Congo, and Zambezi.



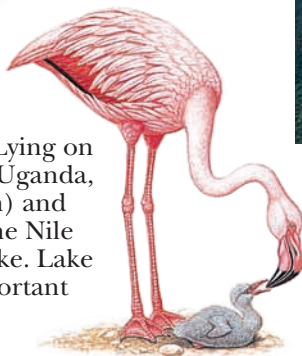
GREAT RIFT VALLEY

The Great Rift Valley stretches from Mozambique in the south, through eastern Africa and the Red Sea, into Syria. In most places the valley is 19–62 miles (30–100 km) wide, with steep sides rising up to 6,562 ft (2,000 m). The valley was formed as blocks of land sank between faults in the Earth's crust. In eastern Africa, the valley has two main branches. The Rift Valley is marked by volcanoes, hot springs, and a long chain of lakes.



LAKE VICTORIA

Lake Victoria is Africa's largest lake and the second largest freshwater lake in the world. Lying on the Equator, between Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda, it covers about 26,828 sq miles (69,484 sq km) and reaches 269 ft (82 m) at its deepest point. The Nile River flows out of the northern end of the lake. Lake Victoria is rich in fish, which provide an important source of income for the large numbers of people living along the lake shores.



Millions of flamingos flock to Lake Turkana and other Rift Valley lakes to nest and feed on tiny water plants.

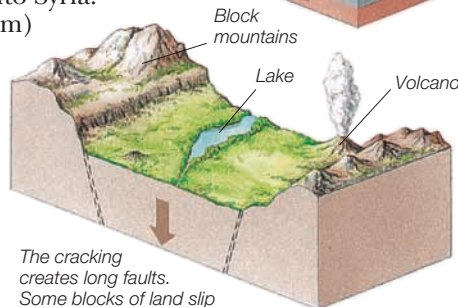
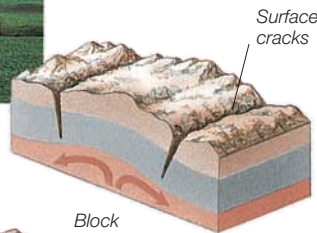


DESERTS

Africa has three huge deserts. The vast Sahara is the world's largest desert and dominates the northern third of the continent. Thousands of years ago the Sahara had a moist climate. Today, the path of wet winds blowing in from the sea is blocked by other winds blowing outward from the desert. The Namib and Kalahari deserts cover vast areas of southwestern Africa. Although it lies along the coast, the Namib Desert (shown here) is particularly barren and dry.

Formation of a rift valley

Movements deep within the Earth's crust cause stretching, and cracks appear on the surface.



The cracking creates long faults. Some blocks of land slip down between parallel faults to create a rift valley.



RAIN FORESTS

The world's second largest rain forest, after the Amazon, lies in central Africa. The Congo teems with plant and animal life, including rare creatures such as okapis. It was also the home of groups of pygmies, but many now live in settled villages, because vast areas of forest have been destroyed for logging and farming. One group, the Bambutu, still live in the northeastern forests of Democratic Republic of Congo.



DRAKENSBERG MOUNTAINS

The highest mountains in southern Africa are the Drakensberg. They form part of the rim of a saucer-shaped plateau of high land called the Great Escarpment. In the local Zulu language, the mountains are known as *Quathlamba*, which means the "barrier of pointed spears." The highest peak, Thabana Ntlenyana, rises 11,424 ft (3,482 m) above sea level and is capped with snow in winter.